

Read **Text A** and answer **Question 1** and **Question 2** on the question paper.

Text A: The kite fighting tournament

The writer is looking back at his childhood in Kabul, Afghanistan.

- 1 My father, Baba, was one of the richest businessmen in Kabul. Everyone agreed that he had built the most beautiful house in the city. It was a huge mansion of marble floors, and crystal chandeliers hung from the ceilings. At the bottom of our garden was the shack, dimly lit by a pair of oil lamps, where our servant, Ali, lived with his son, Hassan. Hassan and I were almost the same age and so inevitably we became friends, but I never stepped inside his home. While I went to school, Hassan stayed home, helping Ali with the chores. 5
- 2 When the sun disappeared and we finished playing for the day, Hassan and I parted ways. I headed to Baba's mansion, Hassan headed to his shack. I'd watch enviously as Ali greeted his son with a warm hug. Legend had it that my own father had wrestled a black bear with his bare hands. No one doubted this. I'd seen the jagged scars on his back, I would boast to the boys at school. But sometimes I dreamt about the bear fight. And in those dreams, I could never tell Baba from the bear. 10
- 3 Winter was every child's favourite season in Kabul. I loved it for the soft pattering of snow against my window at night, for the warmth of the cast-iron stove, for the way fresh snow crunched under my rubber boots, for turnip qurma and rice for lunch after a morning building snowmen. And of course, I loved winter for the kite fighting tournament. The streets filled with kite fighters tugging their strings, squinting up to the sky, trying to cut the opponent's kite line until only one kite remained in the sky – the winner's. 15
- 4 Hassan and I used to build our own kites. We went to the bazaar and bought bamboo, glue, string and paper, but it quickly became apparent that Hassan and I were better kite fighters than kite makers. Some flaw in our design always spelled its doom, so Baba took us to Saifo, the city's most famous kite maker, and bought us a kite and a spool of glass string sharp enough to cut down the other kites. 20
- 5 A few days before the tournament, Baba and I were having dinner. He was telling me again about his kite fighting victories when he said, casually, 'I'm wondering maybe you'll win the tournament this year. What do you think?' I was a good kite fighter and had almost won a few times, but that wasn't good enough for Baba. Winning was winning. Nonetheless, Baba's comment had planted a seed in my head: I would win that winter's tournament. I was going to fly that last kite. I'd show him once and for all that his son was worthy. But, the night before the tournament, I didn't sleep. I rolled from side to side, got up and sat on the balcony in the dark, a blanket wrapped around me. I was like a soldier trying to sleep the night before a battle. Fighting kites was a little like going to war and we had to be prepared. 25 30
- 6 On the morning of the tournament, Hassan and I gathered with the other kite fighters. Rooftops were jammed with spectators. I turned my gaze to our rooftop and found Baba sitting on a bench, wrapped in his woollen coat, sipping tea. I felt Baba watching me. Why was I putting myself through this when I knew the outcome? Suddenly, I wanted to withdraw. Go back home. But Hassan had already raised our red kite and was running. The spool rolled in my hands and he tossed the kite. I took a deep breath, pulled on the string and the kite rocketed to the sky to become a great paper bird flapping its wings. Hassan clapped his hands and raced back to me. I handed him the spool so I could manipulate the string and control the kite. Soon the sky was a sea of gliding kites like paper sharks looking for prey. 35 40

- 7 And then the cutting commenced. The defeated kites whirled out of control. They fell from the sky like shooting stars with brilliant, rippling tails – but I was still flying! Hours later, there were just a few kites left. My legs ached, my neck was stiff but with each defeated kite, hope grew in my heart. Only five kites remained... then four... then three... and then... two – and I was still flying! It was just me and the other guy. The blue kite. And suddenly, just like that, hope became knowledge. I was going to win. It was just a matter of when. 45
- 8 I fed the string, pulled up, looped my red kite on top of the blue one. I held position. The blue kite knew it was in trouble. Sensing the end was near, the crowd were cheering, clapping, chanting. Then the moment came. The crowd erupted when the blue kite spun wildly like a tyre come loose from a speeding car, tumbling and plummeting down. My own kite sailed triumphantly in the empty sky. I blinked, tried to say something and then I was screaming and everything was alive and good. I saw Baba standing on our roof, pumping both of his fists. Hollering and laughing. And that was the single greatest moment of my twelve years of life, seeing Baba on that roof, proud of me at last. 50 55

Read **Text A, The kite fighting tournament**, in the insert and answer **Question 1** and **Question 2**.

Question 1

- (a) From paragraph 1, identify **one** detail about the house that shows that Baba is a successful businessman.

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..... [1]

- (b) Suggest a reason why the writer 'never stepped inside' Hassan's home. (lines 5–6)

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..... [1]

- (c) From paragraph 3, identify **two** things the writer enjoyed about snow.

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- [2]

- (d) From paragraph 4, give **two** reasons why Baba bought the writer and Hassan kites from Saifo.

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- [2]

- (e) **Using your own words**, explain what the text means by 'planted a seed' in the writer's head. (line 28)

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..... [2]



(f) In paragraph 5, how did the writer feel the night before the tournament?

Give **two** details from the text to support your answer.

writer's feeling

details

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[3]

(g) (i) Why did the writer want to 'withdraw' from the tournament? (line 37)

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..... [1]

(ii) Why did the writer **not** withdraw?

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..... [1]

(h) Explain **using your own words** the writer's different feelings and opinions about his father, Baba.

Give **three** details from anywhere in the text to support your answer.

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[Total: 16]

Question 2

- (a) Explain why the writer uses the word 'manipulate' rather than 'hold' in the sentence 'I handed him the spool so I could manipulate the string'. (lines 40–41)

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..... [1]

- (b) What **two** impressions does the writer convey to the reader in the sentence:

'Soon the sky was a sea of gliding kites like paper sharks looking for prey.'? (lines 41–42)

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..... [2]

- (c) Read this sentence from the text:

'They fell from the sky like shooting stars with brilliant, rippling tails – but I was still flying!' (lines 43–44)

What effects does the writer suggest about the falling kites by using the phrase 'like shooting stars'? Give **two** effects.

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..... [2]

- (d) Read this sentence from the text:

'Only five kites remained... then four... then three... and then... two – and I was still flying!' (lines 46–47)

What does the writer want the reader to feel in this sentence?

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..... [1]

(e) Identify **one** example from the text below of how the writer uses language effectively to describe the events at the kite fighting tournament:

‘Sensing the end was near, the crowd were cheering, clapping, chanting. Then the moment came. The crowd erupted when the blue kite spun wildly like a tyre come loose from a speeding car, tumbling and plummeting down. My own kite sailed triumphantly in the empty sky.’ (lines 50–53)

Explain the impression the writer creates in the example you have identified.

example

explanation

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[3]

[Total: 9]